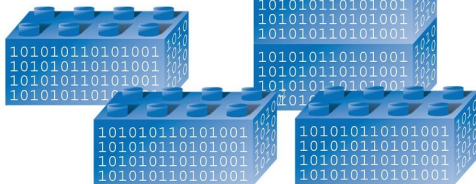


Working with openOffice.org (OOo) Base



Let's explore the power and usability of Base, a database-management program included in the OpenOffice.org (OOo) suite. To get you familiar with Base, we will develop a small database to store the personal records of factory workers, along with the hours they worked.

Base is a powerful database management program that you can use even at your office, without spending a single penny. It supports a number of databases/formats, including MySQL, MS Access, Oracle JDBC, spreadsheets and DBase, besides its own native database format (HSQLDB). Structured Query Language (SQL) is also supported by Base.

Installing Base

OpenOffice.org should come pre-installed on most 'desktop' Linux distributions nowadays. If it's not, then look in your software package management program; you should be able to install it from there. (For RedHat and Fedora, 'yum install <program name>' should install the desired package.) If it is not available there, then you can download the tar.gz file from www.openoffice.org, and extract its contents in a temporary folder. Run the set-up file, and follow the instructions to install it.

Our first Base database

A database can contain tables, queries, forms, reports and code. Data is stored in tables, as *records*, and queries can be used to retrieve the records. Forms are used to provide a user-friendly interface to data from tables or queries.

To create your first database, start OpenOffice, and

click *Database* to start Base, as shown in Figure 1. Select *Create new database* and click *Next*. In the next screen, select *Register my database* and click *Finish*. Name the database (I named mine 'personal') and click *Save*. After saving the database, a new screen will appear, as shown in Figure 2.

Here, as you can see, the window contains four icons, for *Tables*, *Queries*, *Forms* and *Reports*. First select *Tables* and click *Create Table in Design View*. This will open a new window in which you define the fields for the table. Your table will consist of the following fields, as shown in Figure 3:

Name	Type	Purpose
<i>empid</i>	Integer [INTEGER]	Primary key
<i>name</i>	Text [VARCHAR]	
<i>address</i>	Memo [LONGVARCHAR]	
<i>dob</i>	Date [DATE]	Date of birth
<i>photo</i>	Text [VARCHAR]	

Here, *VARCHAR* are character-type fields with variable length, and *INTEGER* are numeric fields. Some fields require special explanation, such as *address* and *photo*. Since the *address* will contain more than one line, we use a memo-type field, *LONGVARCHAR*. I want to have an employee *photo*, but not store the actual image in the